



Albite

△ Nest of gemmy albite crystals surmounted by brookite

Albite is mainly significant as a rock-forming mineral, but it also has some use as a gemstone. It is found as well-formed, glassy, and brittle crystals, and these are often of transparent, gem quality. However, as it is relatively soft and brittle, albite is faceted exclusively for collectors. Indeed, the variety known as peristerite – a mixture of albite and oligoclase (see p.168) – produces a pleasing bluish, moonstone-like sheen when cut *en cabochon*. The mineral mostly occurs as colourless material, but it can also be yellowish, pink, or green.

Specification

Chemical name	Sodium aluminosilicate	Formula	
$\text{NaAlSi}_3\text{O}_8$	Colours	White, colourless, yellow, green	
Structure	Triclinic	Hardness	6–6.5
RI	1.53–1.54	SG	2.6–2.7
Lustre	Vitreous to pearly	Streak	White
Locations	Canada, Brazil, Norway		

Elbaite tourmaline, quartz, and albite

Rough | In this mixed-mineral specimen, albite is host to impressive crystals of pink-purple tourmaline and clear quartz.



Prismatic tourmaline



Albite and tourmaline | Rough | This spectacular specimen features prismatic crystals of elbaite tourmaline resting on albite and quartz.

Large topaz



Albite and topaz | Rough | In this striking specimen from Afghanistan, snowy white, gemmy albite is the groundmass for a topaz weighing around 0.5kg (1lb).

Twinned crystal



Albite group | Rough | The white albite crystals in this dramatic group have the characteristic blocky crystal form of albite, and many show twinning.

Brilliant-cut crown



Mixed-cut albite | Cut | This flawless, oval, bluish albite gemstone is faceted in a mixed cut with a brilliant-cut crown and step-cut pavilion.